



CSS VISTA

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CURRENT AFFAIRS WEEKLY

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TOP DEVELOPMENTS OF THE WEEK



STRATEGIC AFFAIRS

MAKKAH JOINT DEFENCE AGREEMENT

What was signed—and why it changes the regional security equation.



Leaders of Türkiye, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan after signing the agreement in Makkah, 7 August 2026. PHOTOGRAPH: REUTERS



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

On 7 August 2026, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement. The official statement presents it as a defensive arrangement designed to strengthen collective deterrence and expand defence cooperation.

CORE COMMITMENTS

- An armed attack against one state will be regarded as an attack against all.
- The three parties will deepen political, military and defence-industrial coordination.
- The agreement supplements rather than replaces existing alliances and treaties.

WHY NOW?

- The U.S.–Iran war has destabilised the Gulf security environment.
- Shipping through Hormuz and the Red Sea faces repeated attacks and disruption.
- Missile, drone and cyber threats increasingly cross national boundaries.

FOUNDATION AND FOLLOW-UP

- | | |
|-------------|---|
| 17 SEP 2025 | • Pakistan–Saudi Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement |
| 7 AUG 2026 | • Makkah Joint Defence Agreement signed |
| 13 AUG 2026 | • Operational coordination plans announced |

KEY TAKEAWAY



The pact creates a politically powerful mutual-defence promise; its credibility will depend on operational rules, readiness and shared threat assessment.

STRATEGIC AFFAIRS • CONTINUED

FROM DECLARATION TO DETERRENCE

How the three states intend to convert political solidarity into usable military capacity.



Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye sign the accord in Makkah, 7 August 2026.
PHOTOGRAPH: REUTERS



OPERATIONAL ROADMAP

- Establish senior political and military coordination mechanisms.
- Conduct joint land, naval, air and cyber exercises.
- Expand cooperation in air defence and unmanned systems.
- Pursue joint production, technology transfer, artificial intelligence and electronic warfare.

STRATEGIC GAINS

- Wider geographic reach across South Asia, the Gulf and the eastern Mediterranean.
- Greater interoperability and defence-industrial resilience.
- A stronger signal of collective resolve during regional conflict.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Deeper Gulf security and defence-industrial partnerships.
- More diplomatic weight in regional crisis management.
- Potential gains from training, technology and joint production.

RISKS AND LIMITS

- The public text does not specify automatic troop deployments or detailed command arrangements.
- Differing threat perceptions could complicate collective action.
- Pakistan must preserve workable relations with Iran and avoid strategic overextension.

EXAM LENS

1. Does the Makkah Agreement constitute collective defence or strategic signalling?
2. Can minilateral security arrangements supplement formal alliances?



KEY TAKEAWAY

Deterrence will arise from implementation—not merely from the agreement’s language.

DIPLOMACY

PAKISTAN’S IRAN–U.S. MEDIATION

A diplomatic opening survived into the week, but renewed shipping attacks pushed the process towards another impasse.



Pakistan–Iran consultations during the Islamabad peace process, April 2026. PHOTOGRAPH: HANDOUT VIA REUTERS

LATEST POSITION

On 11 August, Pakistan said Washington and Tehran appeared close to “some sort” of agreement. By 12 August, Islamabad still described itself as mediator and facilitator, but no final settlement had been reached and new maritime attacks were weakening confidence.

CONFIRMED FACT

Pakistan facilitated the process; claims of an imminent final deal remained political assessments, not a completed agreement.

KEY TAKEAWAY
Pakistan preserved a channel for diplomacy, but it could not insulate negotiations from military escalation at sea.

HOW THE PROCESS DEVELOPED

- **8 APR** • A ceasefire followed Pakistani mediation.
- **18 JUN** • The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding was electronically signed.
- **21 JUN** • Pakistan and Qatar convened a High-Level Committee meeting in Switzerland.
- **AUGUST** • The 60-day roadmap approached its deadline amid renewed confrontation.

NEGOTIATING ARCHITECTURE

- Political oversight through a High-Level Committee.
- Working groups on nuclear issues, sanctions, monitoring and dispute resolution.
- A communication line for safer commercial passage through Hormuz.
- A de-confliction cell intended to reduce incidents and miscalculation.

DIPLOMACY • CONTINUED

WHY PAKISTAN’S MEDIATION MATTERS

Islamabad’s diplomatic role is inseparable from its security, economic and regional interests.



Pakistan’s Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar meets an Iranian official during the 2026 peace process. PHOTOGRAPH: PAKISTAN MOFA / REUTERS

PAKISTAN’S CORE STAKES

- Prevent conflict spillover along the Pakistan–Iran border.
- Protect energy supplies and limit imported inflation.
- Preserve relations with Iran, the Gulf states and the United States.
- Support navigation through a waterway that carried about one-fifth of global oil and gas shipments before the war.

WHY ISLAMABAD HAS LEVERAGE

- Working diplomatic access to Tehran, Washington and Gulf capitals.
- Prior ownership of the Islamabad MoU and ceasefire process.
- Geographic proximity and direct exposure to regional instability.

CONSTRAINTS

- Iran linked reopening Hormuz to sanctions relief, asset access and security guarantees.
- Washington maintained military and economic pressure.
- Attacks on shipping repeatedly undermined trust.
- Pakistan can facilitate communication but cannot enforce compliance.

PLAUSIBLE SCENARIOS

1. Limited interim arrangement on shipping and de-confliction.
2. Prolonged coercive stalemate with intermittent talks.
3. Renewed escalation if attacks produce mass casualties or major supply disruption.

EXAM LENS

Assess Pakistan’s potential and limitations as a mediator between stronger adversaries.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Successful mediation would advance Pakistan’s strategic autonomy; failure would expose it to higher security and economic costs.

MARITIME SECURITY

RED SEA ATTACK KILLS PAKISTANI SEAFARERS

The human cost of regional escalation reaches Pakistan's merchant-marine community.



Damage aboard a commercial vessel after an earlier 2026 missile attack.
Contextual file photograph; this is not the Tihamah. PHOTOGRAPH: THE DAILY STAR

CONFIRMED DEVELOPMENT

Pakistan's Foreign Office confirmed on 12 August that three Pakistani nationals were killed and one was injured after the Tanzania-flagged cargo vessel Tihamah was attacked near the Bab al-Mandeb Strait. An Indonesian crew member was also reported killed.

WHAT HAPPENED

- The vessel was struck on 11 August near southern Yemen.
- Yemeni and maritime-security sources attributed the attack to the Houthis.
- A second projectile reportedly struck during the rescue operation.
- Pakistan began coordination for assistance, retrieval and repatriation.



KEY TAKEAWAY

The attack transformed a distant shipping crisis into a direct Pakistani human-security concern.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Civilian seafarers are increasingly exposed to regional warfare.
- Bab al-Mandeb links the Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden and global trade routes.
- Attacks raise freight, insurance and rerouting costs.
- Strikes on non-combatant shipping threaten freedom of navigation.

PAKISTAN AND THE MARITIME COALITION

- Pakistan joined the communiqué supporting a Saudi-led maritime-security initiative.
- Islamabad said it was ready to assist in operationalising the coalition.
- Any participation will require clear objectives, legal authority and rules of engagement.

POLICY PRIORITIES

- Strengthen consular and emergency support for Pakistani crews.
- Improve vessel-risk advisories and maritime intelligence sharing.
- Protect navigation without becoming drawn into open-ended conflict.

EXAM LENS

How should Pakistan balance maritime security cooperation with regional escalation risks?

GOVERNANCE AND ELECTIONS

AJK POLLS ENTER A CONTESTED FINAL PHASE

A likely PML-N majority emerges while voting delays, boycotts and unrest test electoral legitimacy.



An earlier AJK polling station. FILE PHOTOGRAPH: GEO NEWS



Rawalakot protest, August 2026. PHOTOGRAPH: DAILY TIMES

LATEST POSITION • 12 AUGUST

- PML-N had secured 25 seats in the 53-seat Legislative Assembly.
- PPP had won 12 seats but alleged irregularities; PML-N denied the allegation.
- PTI boycotted the election, citing fraud concerns.
- Voting in seven constituencies was postponed because of security conditions.
- A rerun at 23 polling stations in two constituencies was scheduled for 15 August.

WHY THE PROCESS WAS STAGGERED

The election was originally due on 27 July but was divided into district-based rounds as unrest and security concerns intensified. The final round scheduled for 10 August could not proceed everywhere.

THE REPRESENTATION DISPUTE

- Twelve constituencies represent refugees from Indian-administered Kashmir living elsewhere in Pakistan.
- Protesters argue that these seats dilute the political weight of residents inside AJK.
- Pakistani authorities reject claims that the arrangement is used to manipulate outcomes.

CLAIMS REQUIRING ATTRIBUTION

The Joint Awami Action Committee claimed that more than 30 people had died around Rawalakot during the wider unrest. The government disputed the figure and its account of responsibility.



KEY TAKEAWAY

The arithmetic favoured PML-N, but a durable mandate required credible completion of voting and political engagement beyond seat totals.

GOVERNANCE AND ELECTIONS • CONTINUED

THE LEGITIMACY TEST IN AJK

The decisive challenge is not merely who forms the government, but whether institutions can restore consent.



Public demonstration in Rawalakot during the 2026 election crisis.
PHOTOGRAPH: DAILY TIMES



Earlier AJK voting.
FILE PHOTOGRAPH: GEO NEWS

STRUCTURAL CAUSES

- Long-running complaints about political influence from Islamabad.
- Disagreement over refugee constituencies and local representation.
- Economic grievances and perceptions of unequal development.
- Weak trust between protesters, parties and regional authorities.

DEMOCRATIC CONCERNS

- Boycott by a major political party reduced competitiveness.
- Road closures and internet disruption restricted campaigning, reporting and public access.
- Delayed constituencies prevented simultaneous completion of the mandate.
- Competing casualty narratives deepened mistrust.

POLICY IMPERATIVES

- Complete postponed voting through transparent procedures and independent observation.
- Publish polling-station results and reasons for any reruns.
- Establish a credible inquiry into deaths, injuries and use of force.
- Open dialogue on representation without prejudging Kashmir's international legal status.
- Restore communications and normal economic activity.

FUTURE SCENARIOS

1. Managed completion followed by a PML-N government.
2. Continued protest if disputed seats determine the majority.
3. Negotiated electoral and governance reforms before the next cycle.

EXAM LENS

Evaluate how electoral design, federal influence and protest governance shape political legitimacy in AJK.

KEY TAKEAWAY



A numerical majority cannot substitute for institutional trust, procedural fairness and peaceful political inclusion.

CYBER GOVERNANCE

PAKISTAN OPENS NATIONAL CYBER OPERATIONS CENTRE

The new institution links real-time threat monitoring with a broader information-security framework.



Islamabad Safe City Command Centre. Contextual file photograph; this is not the NCSOC. PHOTOGRAPH: THE NEWS

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

On 14 August, Federal Minister for Information Technology and Telecommunication Shaza Fatima Khawaja inaugurated the National Cyber Security Operations Centre at National CERT.

CORE FUNCTIONS

- Monitor malicious cyber activity in real time.
- Detect and coordinate responses to cyber threats.
- Support protection of critical information infrastructure.
- Safeguard government services and citizens' data.



KEY TAKEAWAY

NCSOC is an important capability, but resilience will depend on coordination, skilled personnel, lawful oversight and continuous testing.

POLICY ARCHITECTURE

- National CERT provides the institutional base for incident response.
- The Pakistan Information Security Framework 2026 establishes the wider policy direction.
- Government highlighted Pakistan's Tier-1, Role-Modelling status in the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Digital government increases both service capacity and attack surfaces.
- Cyber incidents can disrupt finance, energy, communications and public administration.
- Central coordination can reduce fragmented responses across institutions.

IMPLEMENTATION TESTS

- Clarify responsibilities among federal, provincial, civilian and security bodies.
- Build specialised personnel and retain technical talent.
- Establish independent audits, incident-reporting standards and measurable readiness targets.
- Protect privacy and legal accountability alongside national security.

EXAM LENS

Can institutional centralisation strengthen cyber resilience without weakening transparency and civil liberties?

INTERNAL SECURITY

BALUCHISTAN: A WEEK OF OPERATIONS AND ATTACKS

Surab and Mastung illustrate the continuing contest between militant networks and the state.



Security personnel during an earlier 2026 operation in Pishin, Baluchistan. Contextual file photograph. PHOTOGRAPH: BUSINESS RECORDER

SURAB • 12 AUGUST

According to an ISPR account carried by state media, an under-preparation vehicle-borne improvised explosive device detonated prematurely in Surab district.

OFFICIAL ACCOUNT

- Eight suspected militants were killed in the initial explosion.
- Secondary explosions killed three nearby civilians.
- Security forces and Baluchistan Police launched a joint clearance operation.
- Officials said ten more suspected militants were killed while fleeing.
- Two soldiers were reported injured.

ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

The casualty figures and the description of the militants are official claims. The state's allegation of foreign sponsorship should not be presented as independently established without supporting evidence.

MASTUNG • 14 AUGUST

- Gunmen attacked the convoy of Baluchistan Home Minister Mir Ziaullah Langove near Khad Kocha.
- The minister remained unhurt.
- Six people, including three police personnel, were injured, according to police reporting.

WHAT THE INCIDENTS REVEAL

- Continued militant access to explosives and vehicle-bomb capability.
- Capacity to threaten senior officials and security convoys.
- Serious civilian risk from militant preparation sites and armed exchanges.
- Persistent insecurity across multiple districts despite intensive operations.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Tactical disruption matters, but the week's violence showed that militant capability and civilian exposure remain significant.

INTERNAL SECURITY • CONTINUED

BEYOND TACTICAL SUCCESS

A sustainable Balochistan strategy must connect security operations with legitimacy, justice and governance.



Balochistan Provincial Assembly in Quetta. Contextual file photograph. PHOTOGRAPH: URDU NEWS

THE CENTRAL POLICY PROBLEM

Intelligence-led operations can disrupt cells, seize weapons and prevent attacks, but they cannot by themselves remove the political, institutional and socioeconomic conditions that armed groups exploit.

SECURITY PRIORITIES

- Improve intelligence fusion among police, CTD, Levies and federal agencies.
- Build forensic capacity for explosives, financing and digital communications.
- Protect civilians through disciplined targeting and transparent incident review.
- Strengthen protection of transport corridors, public officials and essential infrastructure.

GOVERNANCE PRIORITIES

- Expand credible local participation in development decisions.
- Improve delivery of education, health, water and employment programmes.
- Investigate abuses and enforced-disappearance allegations through lawful institutions.
- Create political channels that isolate violent actors without closing peaceful dissent.

RISKS OF A KINETIC-ONLY APPROACH

- Civilian harm can deepen alienation and aid militant recruitment.
- Weak public evidence can reduce confidence in official attribution.
- Centralised decisions may marginalise local knowledge and accountability.
- Permanent securitisation can crowd out political solutions.

MEASURING PROGRESS

- Fewer attacks and civilian casualties.
- Higher prosecution quality, not merely arrest totals.
- Greater public cooperation with lawful policing.
- Visible improvement in services and local trust.

EXAM LENS

Critically evaluate why counterterrorism in Balochistan requires a whole-of-government rather than a predominantly military response.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Durable security requires the state to defeat violent networks while simultaneously strengthening rights, representation and public confidence.

PAKISTAN / CLIMATE GOVERNANCE

BALUCHISTAN FLOOD HOUSING A RESTRUCTURING UNDER SCRUTINY

The World Bank warned that redirecting resources from owner-driven reconstruction could leave verified families without support and deepen poverty; Islamabad replied that implementation continues under a revised framework.



Climate-resilient homes in Baluchistan. UNDP file photograph, 2025.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- On 10–11 August, reporting based on official records showed that the Rs115bn Integrated Flood Resilience and Adaptation Project (IFRAP) had been restructured.
- The \$400m programme's \$155m housing component was capped at about 69,000 homes; remaining resources were redirected toward roads and irrigation, while proposed \$180m additional World Bank financing was declined.

WORLD BANK CONCERNS

- Bank country director Bolormaa Amgaabazar said the decision could leave 119,049 verified and eligible households without identified financing.
- The Bank said 84% of eligible households were ultra-poor or vulnerable and 66,120 exclusion-related grievances had been registered by the agreed cut-off.
- It requested transparent, individually verifiable communication and grievance resolution.

GOVERNMENT RESPONSE — 14 AUGUST

- The Planning Ministry said work had started on 74,988 houses and 26,357 had been completed under the owner-driven model.
- Authorities cited slow delivery, land-title and banking barriers, plus alleged record tampering, duplicate claims and multiple payments; an independent inquiry and satellite verification were ordered.

WHY IT MATTERS

- The dispute tests donor confidence, fiduciary control and whether post-disaster commitments reach highly exposed households.
- Redirecting funds may finance useful infrastructure, but excluding verified families creates poverty, legal and social-cohesion risks.

EXAM LENS

- Evaluate how accountability, beneficiary verification and federal–provincial coordination shape climate-resilient reconstruction.

KEY TAKEAWAY



Restructuring may address implementation failures, but legitimacy depends on transparent evidence, credible grievance handling and a financing path for excluded families.

PAKISTAN / URBAN WATER SECURITY

K-IV: KARACHI'S COSTLY WATER LIFELINE

The planning forum advanced a Rs172 billion revision for the 260-MGD phase, targeting June 2027—yet finance, power and distribution must be synchronised before bulk water reaches households.



K-IV pipeline works near Keenjhar Lake. WAPDA file photograph, November 2025.

NUMBERS THAT MATTER



Rs172bn
revised cost



260 MGD
current phase



121 km
conveyance



50 MW
pumping power



June 2027
target

LATEST DEVELOPMENT — 7 AUGUST

- The Central Development Working Party recommended the revised Greater Karachi Bulk Water Supply Scheme (K-IV) to ECNEC for final approval.
- Revised cost: Rs172bn. Current carrying capacity: 260 million gallons per day (MGD).
- WAPDA's chairman put the new completion target at June 2027; financing constraints were cited for delay.

HOW THE PROJECT CHANGED

- The 2007 design envisaged 650 MGD at Rs15.8bn.
- The estimate rose to Rs25.5bn in 2014 after a 50MW power supply, bridges and tunnels were added to the 121-km conveyance system from Keenjhar Lake.
- Contracts for the reduced 260-MGD phase were awarded in June 2022 at Rs98.5bn, with an October 2023 completion date.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Reliable bulk supply is central to public health, productivity and affordability in Pakistan's largest city.
- The scheme could reduce dependence on expensive tanker water, especially for low-income households, but 260 MGD is far below the original 650-MGD ambition.

DELIVERY TEST

- Sindh must align the 50MW power connection and augmentation of Karachi's distribution network with WAPDA's bulk-conveyance schedule.
- A finished trunk system without reliable power, treatment and neighbourhood distribution would not deliver the promised public benefit.

EXAM LENS

Analyse K-IV as a case study in megaproject governance: cost escalation, centre-province coordination, sequencing and urban equity.

KEY TAKEAWAY



The approval revives a critical project, but June 2027 will matter only if finance and last-mile systems move on the same clock.



INTERNATIONAL / MARITIME SECURITY

HORMUZ: A CHOKEPOINT UNDER COERCIVE PRESSURE

By 14 August, traffic remained sharply constrained as Washington threatened a sustained blockade of Iran, Tehran linked reopening to political concessions, and the UAE alleged fresh attacks on two ADNOC vessels.



Oil tankers near the Strait of Hormuz. Reuters file photograph, 11 March 2026.

LATEST POSITION — 14 AUGUST

- Commodity-vessel transits rose to nine on Thursday from five on Wednesday, but remained below the August daily average of 12, according to Kpler.
- Most observed ships used Iranian routes; vessels with tracking switched off make the picture incomplete.
- The UAE accused Iran of attacking two ADNOC vessels on 13 August. No injuries were reported. Present this explicitly as a UAE allegation; Iran had not responded by publication time.

COERCIVE BARGAINING

- U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Washington could sustain its naval blockade of Iran indefinitely by rotating ships.
- U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent signalled additional economic pressure and sanctions.
- Iran tied normal passage to sanctions relief, access to frozen assets and an end to attacks, while asserting control of the waterway.

WHY THE STRAIT MATTERS



About one-fifth of global oil and LNG moved through Hormuz before the war.

RISK LADDER

- **Shipping:** attack, detention, miscalculation and insurance risk.
- **Energy:** delayed cargoes and price volatility.
- **Diplomacy:** every incident narrows space for an enforceable passage arrangement.

ANALYTICAL FRAME

- Neither rival's claim of control creates stable navigation; durable reopening requires rules, monitoring and de-escalation accepted by Gulf states and commercial operators.
- Attribute disputed claims. Do not present military assertions as settled legal fact.

EXAM QUESTION



Assess how maritime chokepoints convert geography into coercive leverage, and why naval power alone cannot guarantee commercial confidence.

KEY TAKEAWAY



Hormuz is not merely closed or open: the decisive variable is whether ships, crews and insurers believe passage is predictably safe.

INTERNATIONAL / GLOBAL ECONOMY & PAKISTAN

THE HORMUZ SHOCKWAVE:
PAKISTAN’S EXPOSURE

A maritime security crisis transmits through crude prices, freight, insurance, exchange reserves and domestic inflation—making de-escalation an economic-security priority for Islamabad.



Crude tanker Pure Point at Karachi port. Arab News file photograph, November 2025.

MARKET SIGNAL — 14 AUGUST

- Brent settled around \$87.87 a barrel, up 5.09% over the week; WTI was about \$81.69, up 4.37%, Reuters reported.
- Tanker attacks, the U.S.–Iran standoff and curtailed passage sustained a risk premium, while inventories and weaker demand expectations provided partial counter-pressure.

TRANSMISSION CHANNELS



INTERNATIONAL / GAZA DIPLOMACY

GAZA ROADMAP: THE SEQUENCING DEADLOCK

A U.S.-led 15-point plan links verified Hamas disarmament to phased Israeli withdrawal, but Israel and Hamas disagree over which commitments must come first.



Donald Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu at a Gaza-plan announcement.
Reuters/Anadolu file photograph, September 2025.

THE CORE DISPUTE

ISRAEL: complete disarmament before withdrawal; all heavy and light weapons included.

HAMAS: endorsed the roadmap text, which links withdrawal and disarmament in phases; says Israel must also halt attacks and meet withdrawal commitments.

U.S./BOARD OF PEACE: implementation and verification should unlock each next stage; talks with Israel continue.

POLITICAL CONSTRAINTS

- Netanyahu faces an October election and resistance from far-right coalition partners.
- Hamas avoids the term “disarmament” and contests later interpretations that go beyond the roadmap text.

WHY IT MATTERS

- A sequencing disagreement can become a veto over the entire transition.
- Verification must be credible to combatants, mediators and civilians; ambiguity invites delay or renewed violence.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- On 9 August, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel did not accept the new 15-point document and would not withdraw until Hamas was fully disarmed.
- On 10 August, an official of Trump’s Board of Peace said the plan remained operative and would advance through verified stages.

WHAT THE ROADMAP PROPOSES

- Immediate cessation of military operations.
- Decommissioning and storage of militia weapons, production sites, depots and tunnels.
- Israeli withdrawal from verified weapon-free sectors.
- Civil administration by the Palestinian technocratic National Committee for the Administration of Gaza.
- An International Stabilization Force (ISF) to secure vacated areas, train Palestinian police and support aid delivery.

EXAM LENS

Distinguish agreement on end-state goals from agreement on implementation order.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The plan’s viability depends less on its list of objectives than on a mutually enforceable first move.

INTERNATIONAL / CONFLICT GOVERNANCE

BEYOND THE ROADMAP: WHO GOVERNS, VERIFIES, REBUILDS?

Even if sequencing is resolved, implementation requires legitimate Palestinian administration, a credible security force, humanitarian access and enforceable guarantees.



Residents walk through destruction in Gaza City. Reuters file photograph, 14 October 2025.

IMPLEMENTATION GAPS

- The National Committee for the Administration of Gaza remained outside the enclave.
- Diplomats said the International Stabilization Force was likely months from deployment.
- Morocco and Uganda had pledged troops; Kosovo, Albania and Kazakhstan offered planners or medics; Indonesia said its talks were on hold.

HUMANITARIAN BASELINE

- Nearly all Gaza’s population of more than 2 million remained confined to a narrow coastal area, largely in tents or damaged buildings.
- Since the October 2025 ceasefire, Gaza health officials reported more than 1,250 Palestinians killed in Israeli attacks, most described as civilians; Israeli tallies recorded four soldiers killed by militants.

FOUR TESTS FOR A DURABLE TRANSITION

1. **Consent:** Palestinians must view the civil authority as representative, not imposed.
2. **Verification:** weapon decommissioning and withdrawals need neutral evidence and dispute resolution.
3. **Security:** policing must protect civilians without reproducing occupation or factional rule.
4. **Reconstruction:** aid, debris removal, housing and services require predictable access and financing.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan can use the UN, OIC and bilateral diplomacy to press for civilian protection, unhindered humanitarian access and Palestinian political agency.
- Support for reconstruction should remain tied to a credible political horizon and international law, not permanent fragmentation.

SCENARIOS — ANALYSIS

- **Phased compliance:** governance and security expand sector by sector.
- **Frozen transition:** ceasefire persists but institutions remain outside Gaza.
- **Breakdown:** disputed verification triggers renewed large-scale violence.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- Can externally sponsored peacebuilding succeed without locally legitimate governance? Evaluate with reference to Gaza.



KEY TAKEAWAY
Disarmament and withdrawal are necessary but insufficient: peace requires institutions that civilians trust and parties cannot easily bypass.

INTERNATIONAL / YEMEN & RED SEA

YEMEN'S TRUCE AT THE EDGE

The UN warned on 13 August that Yemen faced its gravest risk of renewed large-scale conflict since the 2022 truce, as land fighting, attacks on shipping and regional escalation converged.



UN Security Council receives a Yemen briefing from Hans Grundberg. UN Photo file image, January 2026.

LATEST WARNING — 13 AUGUST

- UN envoy Hans Grundberg told the Security Council that military activity had intensified along frontlines.
- Recent Houthi attacks in Marib, Hadramawt, Mocha and elsewhere caused military and civilian casualties, he said.
- Renewed attacks on commercial vessels in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden risked drawing Yemen into a wider regional war.

ESCALATION DURING THE WEEK

- On 9 August, the Houthis said they struck Saudi Aramco's Jazan refinery; Saudi authorities reported a fire extinguished with no injuries but did not state the cause.
- Attacks also hit Mocha port, while a deadly 11 August strike on the cargo ship Tihamah killed crew members and rescuers.
- The attacks widened risks to ports, energy infrastructure and civilian navigation.

HUMANITARIAN ALARM



More than half the population faces acute food insecurity.



Six million people are on the brink of famine, according to the UN humanitarian chief.



The Houthis hold 73 UN personnel, alongside NGO, civil-society and diplomatic workers.

WHY 2022 STILL MATTERS

- The UN-mediated truce sharply reduced large-scale fighting but did not produce a final political settlement.
- A regional maritime confrontation can now reactivate unresolved domestic frontlines.

PAKISTAN CONNECTION

- Three Pakistani sailors were among those killed on Tihamah, giving maritime security a direct human dimension.
- The Jazan strike followed the Saudi–Türkiye–Pakistan defence pact; Reuters noted it was unclear how Islamabad or Ankara might join any response.
- Pakistan therefore needs precise alliance consultation, protection of seafarers and support for UN de-escalation.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- How do regional proxy dynamics undermine conflict-management arrangements that lack a comprehensive political settlement?



KEY TAKEAWAY

Yemen's relative calm was a truce, not peace; maritime escalation may collapse the boundary between domestic and regional war.

INTERNATIONAL / UKRAINE & FOOD SECURITY

BLACK SEA TRUCE REJECTED AS THE GRAIN CORRIDOR FRAYS

Russia dismissed a proposed pause in attacks on civilian shipping on 14 August, while strikes on ports and vessels squeezed Ukrainian exports and raised global food-security risks.



Grain is loaded at a Ukrainian Black Sea port.
Reuters file photograph, 14 August 2022.

WHY THE 2022–23 DEAL MATTERS

- The former UN- and Türkiye-brokered initiative showed that inspection rules and guarantees can preserve trade during war.
- Moscow withdrew in 2023, saying commitments on Russian food and fertiliser trade were not met.

DIPLOMATIC OPTIONS

- A narrow civilian-shipping moratorium with independent monitoring.
- Separate military and commercial traffic through notification and verification.
- Security assurances that do not confer strategic advantage on either belligerent.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Global wheat volatility can transmit into food prices, fiscal pressure and import planning even when domestic supply is the first line of defence.
- Pakistan should track cargo availability, diversify origins and support protected food corridors through multilateral diplomacy.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- Can functional cooperation on food trade survive when a broader ceasefire is politically impossible?

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Ukraine offered, through a third party, a halt to attacks on civilian shipping in the Black Sea.
- Russia said it had received no formal proposal and rejected “half-measures” that it argued would benefit Ukraine.
- Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan had been pursuing a maritime moratorium, according to reporting cited by Reuters.

WHAT IS HAPPENING AT SEA

- Russia and Ukraine have attacked each other's ports, export infrastructure and vessels.
- Russia's de facto pressure on Odesa-region ports sharply reduced ship movements; alternative routes cannot fully replace Black Sea capacity.

GRAIN IMPACT

- Ukrainian grain exports fell 76% year-on-year in the first two weeks of August, according to the agriculture ministry.
- Kyiv cut its 2026/27 grain-export forecast by as much as 12%, citing attacks on southern ports.
- Farmers face trapped stocks and weak domestic prices even as global grain prices rise.



KEY TAKEAWAY

The Black Sea dispute demonstrates how attacks on logistics turn a regional war into a global food-security shock.

INTERNATIONAL / PEACE PROCESS

TÜRKİYE LEGISLATES A PATH OUT OF PKK CONFLICT

A landmark 10 August law creates a framework for disarmament and reintegration after four decades of conflict—but durable peace still requires trust, rights and accountable implementation.



The Grand National Assembly of Türkiye in session. File photograph.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT — 10 AUGUST

- Parliament passed a legal framework to advance the PKK’s disbandment and reintegration of eligible former militants.
- The measure won 468 votes in the 600-seat assembly, with support from the ruling AK Party, nationalist MHP and pro-Kurdish DEM Party.

WHAT THE LAW DOES

- Provides legal protection and possible sentence suspension for many former militants who have not committed specified offences.
- Creates procedures intended to move fighters out of armed structures and back into civilian life.
- Treats disarmament as a legal and administrative process, not only a military event.

BACKGROUND

- The PKK insurgency began in 1984 and has killed more than 40,000 people.
- Jailed PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan called in February 2025 for the group to disband.
- In May 2025, the PKK announced an end to its armed struggle.

WHAT REMAINS UNRESOLVED

- The law does not settle wider Kurdish political and cultural-rights demands.
- It does not comprehensively reform anti-terrorism laws or determine Öcalan’s status.
- Veterans and families of those killed fear that reintegration may dilute accountability; many Kurdish families remain sceptical of state guarantees.

PEACEBUILDING TEST



Explain: weapons exit, command structures dissolve, livelihoods and legal status follow, grievances move into democratic politics.

REGIONAL SIGNIFICANCE

- Implementation affects Türkiye’s security relations with Iraq and Syria, where Kurdish armed networks and cross-border operations complicate the process.

COMPARATIVE LESSON

- For states facing insurgency, sequencing matters: security guarantees without rights lack legitimacy; amnesty without accountability lacks public trust.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- Evaluate whether DDR can end an insurgency without parallel political and constitutional reform.

KEY TAKEAWAY



The law opens an exit from violence, but peace will be measured by institutions, rights and public confidence—not the passage of legislation alone.

INTERNATIONAL / SYRIA & GREAT-POWER STRATEGY

SYRIA RESETS THE TERMS OF RUSSIA'S BASES

An August memorandum preserves a reduced Russian military role at Tartous and Hmeimim while restoring Syrian control over civilian facilities—a negotiated shift from patronage toward conditional access.



Russian military facility at Tartous, Syria. Contextual file photograph.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- On 9 August, Syria and Russia announced a memorandum of understanding after 18 months of negotiations over Tartous and Hmeimim.
- Syria will take control of civilian facilities, including Hmeimim airport and the commercial pier at Tartous.
- Military areas are to become joint training and qualification centres; a source said some Russian forces would remain.

WHAT CHANGES — restrained before/after comparison

BEFORE: broad Russian operational access under arrangements rooted in the Assad era.

AFTER: Syrian jurisdiction over civilian assets; narrower, jointly framed military cooperation; a three-month transition timetable.

IMPLEMENTATION THIS WEEK

- On 12 August, Tartous received wheat and cement at Berth 4, the first civilian shipments through the pier after the new agreement.
- Russian forces were seen vacating nearby buildings and moving to military areas.

WHY TARTOUS & HMEIMIM MATTER

- Tartous is Russia's only naval maintenance facility in the Mediterranean.
- Hmeimim supports air operations and logistics linking the Middle East, Mediterranean and Africa.
- For Damascus, the sites are tests of sovereignty, economic recovery and balanced external relations after Bashar al-Assad's fall in 2024.

STRATEGIC READING

- Russia retains a foothold without the privileges it held under its former ally.
- Syria gains civilian control but still values training, equipment and diplomatic ties.
- The arrangement shows that base access can survive regime change when renegotiated around host-state sovereignty.

RISKS & OPEN QUESTIONS

- Exact force levels and operational permissions remain unclear.
- Joint training centres may blur the line between cooperation and foreign presence.
- Future sanctions, regional conflict or domestic opposition could alter implementation.



KEY TAKEAWAY

The deal is neither a full Russian withdrawal nor a return to the Assad-era status quo; it is conditional strategic accommodation.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- How does regime change reshape—but not necessarily end—great-power military access?

INTERNATIONAL / MARINE ENVIRONMENT

OMAN OIL SPILL: A SHADOW-FLEET WARNING

A sanctioned tanker carrying Russian crude leaked for weeks beside a protected marine reserve, exposing how opaque ownership, weak oversight and geopolitical risk can magnify environmental damage.



Satellite view of the grounded Caroline Bezenqi near Qibliyah Island.
Planet Labs PBC/AP file image, early August 2026.

LATEST POSITION — 14 AUGUST

- The Caroline Bezenqi remained grounded near Oman’s Hallaniyat Islands after an unexplained 8 June incident.
- The tanker had loaded nearly one million barrels of Russian crude for Asia.
- Oil reached Oman’s mainland coastline on 12 August; specialist salvage vessels and containment equipment were heading to the area by 13 August.

WHY RESPONSE WAS DIFFICULT

- The ship is linked to Russia’s opaque “shadow fleet” and is under sanctions in several jurisdictions.
- Unclear ownership, flag status, insurance and legal authority complicate salvage, financing and liability.
- Rough monsoon seas increased the danger of structural failure and

THE SIZE — FIGURES DIFFER

- Omani authorities reported roughly 400 sq km affected on 10 August.
- Greenpeace estimated about 600 sq km using satellite imagery.
- By 14 August, later satellite analysis cited by Reuters estimated the wider slick at about 2,000 sq km.



Different dates and detection methods account for materially different estimates.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- The incident was not confirmed as a direct threat to Pakistan by publication time.
- It nevertheless strengthens the case for Arabian Sea satellite monitoring, port contingency plans, regional information-sharing and clear polluter-liability rules.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- How do sanctions-evasion networks create environmental-governance risks beyond their original geopolitical purpose?

KEY TAKEAWAY



The spill is both an ecological emergency and a governance failure: hazardous cargo becomes harder to contain when responsibility is deliberately obscured.

ECOLOGICAL STAKES

- The Hallaniyat reserve supports sensitive seabirds, coral and the endangered Arabian Sea humpback whale.
- Oil in shallow coastal water can smother habitats, contaminate food chains and persist in sediments.

VERIFIED SOURCES • Oman Environment Authority figures reported by Reuters, 10 Aug 2026
• Greenpeace satellite assessment • Reuters, 12–14 Aug 2026 • Planet Labs/AP imagery

INTERNATIONAL / AFGHANISTAN & EDUCATION

AFGHAN GIRLS: FIVE YEARS OF LOST CLASSROOMS

UNESCO reported that 2.4 million girls were excluded from secondary education by 2026, making Afghanistan the only country formally barring girls and women from education beyond primary level.



Primary-school girls study in Mazar-i-Sharif—one of the levels still open to girls. UNICEF/Mark Naftalin file photograph, 2023.

SYSTEM-WIDE CRISIS



2.13 million
primary-age children out of school.



37%
national literacy rate.



93%
of children completing primary school still working toward basic reading proficiency.



Nearly half of schools lack clean water, sanitation or heating.

WHY THE BAN AFFECTS EVERYONE

- Fewer educated women means fewer female teachers, nurses, doctors and community workers.
- In settings where women often receive services from women, the education ban weakens health and humanitarian delivery.
- UNESCO estimated that exclusion from women's higher education could cost up to \$9.6bn in lost potential by 2066.

ALTERNATIVE PATHWAYS

- Since 2021, UNESCO literacy and skills programmes have reached more than 69,000 learners; 73% were women.
- In 2026, UNESCO supported over 26,000 learners, half of them women.
- Community classes, radio, television and online courses preserve learning, but UNESCO stresses they cannot replace formal schooling.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT — 11–14 AUGUST

- UNESCO renewed its call for the immediate restoration of secondary and higher education for girls and women.
- An estimated 2.4 million girls are excluded from secondary education.
- Women have remained barred from universities since December 2022.

REVERSAL OF PROGRESS

- By 2021, nearly one million Afghan girls were enrolled in secondary school after two decades of expansion.
- Secondary schools did not reopen to girls in March 2022; the de facto authorities describe restriction as temporary but had announced no reopening date by publication.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- The policy affects refugee education, border communities, regional human development and Afghanistan's long-term stability.
- Pakistan can support safe learning for Afghan refugees and maintain diplomatic advocacy for education consistent with fundamental rights.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTION

- Assess education exclusion as a human-security and state-capacity crisis, not merely a women's-rights issue.



KEY TAKEAWAY
A country cannot rebuild its economy, health system or institutions while deliberately excluding half its population from advanced learning.

WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY-BY-DAY CURRENT AFFAIRS

A concise verified chronology of the most consequential
Pakistan and international developments, 7–14 August 2026.

7 AUGUST

REGIONAL SECURITY

- Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, treating an armed attack on one as an attack on all.

PAKISTAN

- CDWP recommended the revised Rs172bn K-IV scheme to ECNEC; the current phase targets 260 MGD and completion by June 2027.

8 AUGUST

DIPLOMACY

- Türkiye described the trilateral pact as defensive and Article-5-like; ministerial coordination and a Saudi-based secretariat were planned.

9 AUGUST

GAZA

- Benjamin Netanyahu rejected the U.S.-led 15-point roadmap as it stood, insisting on complete Hamas disarmament before Israeli withdrawal.

SYRIA

- Damascus and Moscow announced an MoU redefining arrangements at Tartous and Hmeimim after 18 months of talks.

10 AUGUST

TÜRKİYE

- Parliament passed a PKK disarmament and reintegration law by 468 votes in the 600-seat chamber.

PAKISTAN

- Third-phase AJK polling proceeded in four Bagh and Haveli constituencies; voting in other Poonch seats had been postponed over security concerns.

11 AUGUST

PAKISTAN

- The World Bank warned that restructuring Balochistan's housing project could leave 119,049 verified eligible households without identified financing.

RED SEA

- An attack on Tihamah killed four crew, including three Pakistanis, plus two Yemeni rescuers; the Houthi claim about its cargo remained unverified.

12 AUGUST

OMAN

- Oil from the grounded Caroline Bezeni reached the mainland coast as spill response and salvage preparations intensified.

SYRIA

- Tartous Berth 4 received its first civilian wheat and cement shipments after the new Syria–Russia agreement.

13 AUGUST

YEMEN

- The UN envoy warned that Yemen faced its highest risk of renewed large-scale war since the 2022 truce.

HORMUZ

- The UAE accused Iran of attacking two ADNOC vessels; no injuries were reported, and Iran had not confirmed the allegation.

14 AUGUST

BLACK SEA

- Russia rejected a proposed civilian-shipping moratorium and said it had received no formal offer.

HORMUZ

- Commodity transits remained below the August average amid the U.S.–Iran coercive standoff.



CSS VISTA

WITH SADIA ZAHOOR
& ALI HASSAN SARGANA

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CURRENT AFFAIRS WEEKLY

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